

SME South Africa — Phase 3 SEO Implementation

Prepared: May 2026 | **Follows:** Phase 1 + Phase 2 briefs **For:** Editor + Developer | **Stack:** WordPress / Yoast SEO Premium / Link Whisper / Tshepho's Ops

Phase 3 at a Glance

Phase 3 has three parts with different time horizons:

Part	Scope	Effort	Expected impact timeline
A — Content Consolidation	6 content clusters still fragmented	3-5 editor days + 2 dev hours	8-14 weeks (ranking recovery)
B — Orphan Audit Operation	274 orphan posts — categorised and actioned	1 editor day + 4 dev hours	8-16 weeks (quality signal recovery)
C — Technical + Monitoring	Yoast/sitemap audit, Link Whisper review, monthly dashboard	1 dev day setup	Ongoing

The biggest single action in this entire three-phase programme is Part B — specifically, the noindex/redirect of 238 thin 2014 posts. Until those pages are removed from Google's crawl queue, every content improvement competes against a backdrop of hundreds of low-quality pages pulling the domain-wide quality signal down.

PART A — Content Consolidation (Third Layer)

The content consolidation pattern is now well-established. Briefs below follow the same structure as Phases 1 and 2 but at a more concise level — your editor and developer understand the playbook.

Brief 10 — Business Loans Consolidation (4 → 1)

Priority: CRITICAL | **Type:** Consolidation | **Effort:** 0.5 days editor + 30 mins dev

Current state — worst remaining fragmentation

Four pages competing for identical "business loans" queries:

URL	Impressions	Clicks	CTR	Position
/sme-review/top-business-loans-for-small-businesses-in-south-africa/	137,688	180	0.13%	37.73
/6-types-of-business-loans-for-smes/	92,110	165	0.18%	38.49
/sme-guides/guide-to-business-loans/	87,903	113	0.13%	39.26
/sme-guides/requirements-for-business-loans-in-south-africa-in-2022/	72,462	242	0.33%	42.67

Combined: 390K impressions, 700 clicks, all at pos 37-43. The 2022 in the last URL's slug alone tells you this content is stale. Four pages competing, none capable of escaping page 4.

Key queries: "business loans" (broad, high volume), "small business loans south africa", "requirements for business loans south africa" — these don't appear in the top 1000 GSC tracked queries because the site ranks so poorly they generate minimal impressions at query level.

Action plan

Keep: </sme-review/top-business-loans-for-small-businesses-in-south-africa/> (Highest impressions; "top" in URL aligns with commercial review intent)

Redirect all three to canonical:

- </6-types-of-business-loans-for-smes/> → 301 → canonical
- </sme-guides/guide-to-business-loans/> → 301 → canonical
- </sme-guides/requirements-for-business-loans-in-south-africa-in-2022/> → 301 → canonical

Content refresh: 2,000–2,500 words. Structure:

H1: Best Business Loans for South African SMEs in 2026 (With Requirements)
H2: Types of Business Loans Available in South Africa
H3: Working Capital Loans [link → /sme-funding/working-capital-loans/]
H3: Unsecured Business Loans [link → /sme-funding/unsecured-loans/]
H3: Government Development Finance (SEDA, NEF, SEFA) [link → /guide-government-funding/]
H3: Purchase Order Financing
H3: Invoice Discounting / Bridging Finance [link → /sme-funding/bridging-finance/]
H2: Requirements for a Business Loan in South Africa (General Checklist)
H2: How to Improve Your Chances of Approval
H2: Top Private Business Lenders – Comparison Table (2026 updated)
H2: FAQ [schema]

Yoast:

- SEO Title: Best Business Loans for South African SMEs in 2026 – Compare Options | SME South Africa
- Meta: Compare business loans available to South African SMEs in 2026. Government and private options, requirements, costs and how to apply.
- Focus keyword: business loans south africa
- Cornerstone: ON

Internal links inbound from: /guide-government-funding-small-businesses/ ("working capital loan options"), /sme-funding/ hub, /sme-resources/business-plan-template/ ("lenders require a business plan")

Success metrics: Target pos 10-20; clicks 3,000-6,000/month from ~700

Brief 11 — Sales Strategy Hub (Forum → Article)

Priority: HIGH | **Type:** New hub article displacing forum thread | **Effort:** 1 day editor

Current state

URL	Impressions	Clicks	CTR	Posit
[forum] effective_sales_strategies_and_tactic_to_drive_significant_revenue	380,191	176	0.05%	27.92

380K impressions on a forum thread at 0.05% CTR — the same structural problem as the registration forum thread (870K impressions). People want a guide, not a forum discussion. There is no existing article on the main domain targeting this query cluster.

Relevant queries from GSC:

- "most profitable business in south africa" — 3,162 imp, 5.15% CTR, pos 4.91
- "most profitable franchises" — 2,085 imp, 5.04% CTR, pos 5.99
- "affiliate marketing" — 20,256 imp, 1.07% CTR, pos 7.84 ← existing page covers this
- "4 key steps to building a world-class sales team" (orphan pos 8, Category A)

Action plan

Publish new article: /sme-guides/sales-strategies-for-small-businesses-in-south-africa/

After publishing, add a pinned mod note in the forum thread: "For a full guide on sales strategies for your SME, see: [Effective Sales Strategies for South African Small Businesses] (link)."

Content structure (target 2,200–2,800 words):

H1: Effective Sales Strategies for Small Businesses in South Africa (2026 Guide)

H2: Why South African SMEs Struggle With Sales
[Brief contextual framing: cash flow, competition from large retailers, digital shift]

H2: Building Your Sales Foundation

- H3: Know Your SA Customer – Segmenting Your Market
- H3: Pricing for the South African Market (ZAR context, township/suburban divide)
- H3: Your Value Proposition in a Price-Sensitive Market

H2: Online Sales Channels for South African SMEs

- H3: Selling on Takealot [link → /how-to-become-a-seller-on-takealot/]
- H3: WhatsApp Business as a Sales Tool
- H3: Social Media Selling (Instagram, Facebook Marketplace)
- H3: Building Your Own E-commerce Presence [link → /e-commerce-questions-answered/]

H2: Offline and Community Sales Tactics

- H3: Stokvel and Community Network Selling
- H3: Spaza-to-Spaza Partnerships
- H3: Trade Shows and Local Markets

H2: Building a Sales Team – When and How
[Link → Category A orphan: "4 Key Steps to Building a World-class Sales Team"]

H2: Measuring Sales Performance – KPIs for SMEs
[Simple: conversion rate, average order value, customer acquisition cost, repeat rate]

H2: Frequently Asked Questions [schema]

- Q: What is the most effective sales strategy for a small South African business?
- Q: How can I increase sales without a marketing budget?
- Q: Should I hire a sales rep or sell myself?

Yoast:

- **SEO Title:** Sales Strategies for South African SMEs: A Practical 2026 Guide | SME South Africa
- **Meta:** Practical, SA-specific sales strategies for small business owners. Online and offline tactics, customer acquisition, and how to build a sales pipeline on a small budget.
- **Focuskeyphrase:** sales strategies for small businesses south africa
- **Secondary:** how to increase sales small business south africa

Internal links inbound: Forum pinned note, /5-key-success-factors-of-businesses/ (145K imp), /top-10-most-successful-businesses-to-start/ (533K imp — add a "once you've chosen your business, here's how to sell" contextual link)

Brief 12 — Labour Law Guide Refresh

Priority: MEDIUM | Type: Single-page refresh | Effort: 0.5 days editor

Current state

URL	Impressions	Clicks	CTR	Position
/sme-guides/guide-to-south-african-labour-law/	109,105	422	0.39%	29.91

Target queries: "basic conditions of employment act" (2,799 imp, pos 16.5), "employment contract template south africa" (893 imp, pos 14.98). No fragmentation issue — single page, single action.

Action plan

Full refresh only. No redirect needed. Target: 2,000–2,500 words.

This is likely a 2020–2022 article that hasn't been updated. Key 2025/2026 relevance hooks:

- NMW (National Minimum Wage) — updated figures (check DoEL for current rate)
- Remote and hybrid work norms post-pandemic (employee rights, home office deductions)
- CCMA dispute volumes and the rise of unfair dismissal claims for SMEs
- Employment Equity Act Amendment updates

Content structure:

H1: South African Labour Law for Small Business Owners: A 2026 Guide
H2: The BCEA – Basic Conditions of Employment Act (What You Must Know)
H3: Working Hours and Overtime Rules
H3: Leave Entitlements (annual, sick, family responsibility, maternity)
H3: Notice Periods by Employee Category
H2: Employment Contracts – What Must Be in Writing
[Offer downloadable template – gated or free, same as business plan opportunity]
H2: The National Minimum Wage (2026 rates)
H2: UIF – Registering and Contributing
H2: Disciplinary Procedures and the CCMA
H3: Before You Dismiss Anyone – The Checklist
H3: When an Employee Takes You to the CCMA
H2: Employment Equity – Do SMEs Need to Comply?
H2: Frequently Asked Questions [schema]

Yoast:

- SEO Title: South African Labour Law for SMEs: The 2026 Plain-Language Guide | SME South Africa
- Meta: Everything South African small business owners need to know about labour law – BCEA, employment contracts, dismissals, CCMA, NMW and UIF. Updated 2026.
- Focus keyphrase: labour law south africa small business
- Cornerstone: ON

Add employment contract template as a gated or free download — same model as the business plan template.

Internal links: → registration hub ("hiring requires UIF registration"), → tax hub ("PAYE once you employ staff")

Brief 13 — Business Licenses Hub

Priority: MEDIUM-HIGH | Type: New hub + forum link | Effort: 1 day editor

Current state — forum thread outranking an existing article

URL	Impressions	Clicks	CTR	Position
[forum] How_to_Obtain_a_Business_License_Application_Form	163,260	589	0.36%	9.03
/faqs-licenses-and-permits-food-service-2/	304,845	4,164	1.37%	11.34
/sme-guides/business-licences-in-south-africa/	153,986	1,572	1.02%	10.49

The food license/permits page is the strongest performer. The business licences guide is close to it in position. Neither competes well for the broad "business license" head term because the forum thread ranks above both.

However: the food license page at 305K impressions and 1.37% CTR is actually performing reasonably well. This isn't a consolidation situation — it's a **hierarchy problem**. The licences guide should be the hub that the food, liquor, and other specific license pages feed from.

Action plan

Make </sme-guides/business-licences-in-south-africa/> **the definitive hub**. Refresh it to rank for the broad "how to get a business license in South Africa" query, then structure it to link out to specific license pages.

Forum thread: Add pinned note linking to the hub article.

Refresh content structure:

H1: How to Get a Business Licence in South Africa (2026 Guide)

H2: Do You Need a Licence to Operate Your Business?

[Types requiring a licence: food/restaurant, liquor, security, childcare, health, construction, financial services, transport. Types that don't: basic retail, consulting, most professional services]

H2: The 5 Most Common Business Licences in South Africa

H3: Food Premises Licence (Certificate of Acceptability)

[Summary + link → /faqs-licenses-and-permits-food-service-2/]

H3: Liquor Licence

[Summary + link → /requirements-for-a-liquor-license/]

H3: Health and Safety Certificate

H3: Security Business Licence (PSIRA registration)

[Summary + link → /how-to-start-a-security-company-in-south-africa/]

H3: Municipal Trading Permit (for informal/street traders)

H2: Where to Apply – CIPC, Local Municipality, or Relevant Authority

H2: How Long Does Licensing Take and What Does It Cost?

H2: What Happens If You Operate Without the Required Licence?

H2: FAQ [schema]

Internal links inbound from: registration hub ("licensing requirements after registration"), /faqs-licenses-and-permits-food-service-2/, /requirements-for-a-liquor-license/, sales strategy hub

Priority: MEDIUM | Type: Individual page refreshes | Effort: 0.5 days each (5 pages = 2.5 days)

These pages follow the same pattern as the successful gas/security/hair salon/vending guides in Phase 1. All are stuck at pos 21–36 with substantial impression volumes. No consolidation needed — individual refreshes with the same treatment: depth, 2026 data, FAQ schema, updated title tags.

Page	Impressions	Clicks	CTR	Position	Refresh focus
/sme-guides/a-guide-to-opening-a-coffee-shop/	130,510	2,340	1.79%	21.84	Health regs, POS, SA coffee market, Checklist
/how-to-start-a-cleaning-services-business/	100,405	827	0.82%	32.63	2026 rates, PSIRA (if applicable), contracts, staff
/how-to-start-an-airbnb-business-in-south-africa/	88,969	1,059	1.19%	26.56	"without owning property" angle (high CTR query), 2026 STR rules
/how-to-start-a-real-estate-business-in-south-africa/	81,420	1,174	1.44%	26.26	Estate agent registration (EA Board), PropTech tools
/how-to-start-a-logistics-company-in-south-africa/	71,533	1,466	2.05%	22.12	CIPC + RFA registration, last-mile delivery boom

Standard refresh protocol for each page:

1. Update title tag to include "(2026)"
2. Update/verify all factual claims, costs, and regulatory requirements
3. Add FAQ schema section (5–7 questions per page)
4. Add a named author or editor attribution
5. Update "last reviewed" date
6. Add internal links: each guide should link to the registration hub, relevant license hub, and the funding hub ("funding options once you've launched")
7. Submit URL via GSC → Request Indexing after publishing

Priority order: Coffee shop first (highest impressions at pos 21); logistics last (already has the best CTR of the five).

Brief 15 — /sme-review/ Category: Annual Refresh Protocol

Priority: LOW-MEDIUM | Type: Process / editorial calendar | Effort: Ongoing

There are at least 7 active [/sme-review/](#) pages stuck at pos 23–42, all covering products that change price and availability regularly:

Page	Impressions	Position	Issue
/sme-review/top-accounting-software-for-small-businesses-in-south-africa-2/	151,020	32.04	Stale pricing/features, "-2" suffix = duplicate risk
/sme-review/top-business-insurance-companies-for-small-businesses/	138,176	23.33	Insurance landscape changes annually
/sme-review/top-business-loans-for-small-businesses-in-south-africa/	137,688	37.73	Consolidated to canonical in Brief 10
/sme-review/top-pos-systems-for-small-businesses/	76,402	36.70	POS market evolves rapidly
/sme-review/top-payroll-and-hr-software-in-south-africa/	77,968	42.63	Check if relevant current tools are covered
/best-business-banking-cards-for-smes/	102,104	31.77	Competing with /sme-review/top-business-credit-cards/ (96K imp)
/sme-review/top-business-credit-cards-for-small-businesses-in-south-africa/	96,826	23.58	Competing with banking cards page above

Immediate actions (developer):

1. Check for the "-2" suffix on [/top-accounting-software-for-small-businesses-in-south-africa-2/](#) — if a [-1](#) or clean URL version exists, this is another duplicate. Redirect to canonical.
2. Consolidate the banking/credit card pages: keep [/sme-review/top-business-credit-cards-for-small-businesses-in-south-africa/](#) (better position), redirect [/best-business-banking-cards-for-smes/](#) → 301 → it.

Editorial protocol (ongoing): Add all [/sme-review/](#) pages to an annual refresh calendar. Each page should be reviewed and updated once per year, with the title tag "(2026)" updated to the current year. Google gives significant ranking preference to recently updated review/comparison content. A single annual pass covering all review pages (typically November–January when SA businesses plan for the new year) is the most efficient approach.

PART B — The Orphan Audit Operation

Framework Summary

All 274 orphaned posts have been classified using four decision criteria: current average position, organic traffic signal, content theme, and commercial relevance to the site's pillars.

Category	Count	Action	Rationale
A — Refresh + Link	18	Update content, add internal links (via Link Architect)	Active ranking signals — worth investing in
B — Light Refresh + Link	7	Minor update (date, accuracy check), add 2-3 internal links	Ranking but thin — small investment, meaningful upside
C — Keep + Link only	12	No content changes. Add 1-2 contextual internal links only	Ranking on niche/branded queries; link equity preserved
D — Prune / Redirect	238	Noindex OR 301 redirect to relevant hub page	Zero traffic, no rankings worth preserving; quality signal drag

Critical implementation note for Category D: Do not noindex all 238 posts at once. Google's crawlers respond better to gradual changes. **Process in batches of 25-30 posts per week over 8-10 weeks.** Prioritise posts with zero ranking first (the lowest-risk removals).

Category A — Refresh + Link (18 posts)

These 18 posts have active position signals. Most were already part of the Phase 1 Link Architect brief (posts 1, 3, 5, 6, 7). The remaining posts need both a content refresh and inbound links added via Tshepho's Ops Link Architect.

Content refresh rule: All Category A posts are from 2014. Any post referencing specific companies, programmes, funders, or individuals should be verified for accuracy before being linked. If a company no longer exists or a programme has ended, update or redirect.

#	Title	URL	Position	Theme	Refresh priority	Link target
1	Do You Need a Business Plan, Yes or No?	/business-plans-yes-or-no/	1.0	Advice	High — link to business plan hub	→ /sme-resources/business-plan-template/
2	'Sell what they need' and Customer Sales Principles	/sell-need-not-youve-got-sales-principles-follow/	1.5	Growth	Medium — update with modern SA sales context	→ /sme-guides/sales-strategies-for-small-businesses/
3	8 Ways The Consumer Protection Act Affects You	/8-ways-consumer-protection-act-affects/	6.0	Legal	High — verify Act provisions still current	→ /sme-guides/business-licences-in-south-africa/
4	4 Key Steps to Building a World-class Sales Team	/4-key-steps-building-world-class-sales-team/	8.0	Growth	Medium — general content, light update	→ /sme-guides/sales-strategies-for-small-businesses/
5	Focus on The Black Business Suppliers Grant	/focus-black-business-suppliers-grant/	9.5	Funding	High — verify grant still active and correct funder	→ /guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
6	5 Laws Every Business Owner can't Afford to Ignore	/5-laws-every-business-owner-cant-afford-ignore/	11.2	Legal	High — verify all 5 laws still current/relevant	→ /sme-guides/business-licences-in-south-africa/
7	'Capitalise On What You Know' – Lynette Magasa	/capitalise-know-lynette-magasa/	11.7	Funding	Low — founder profile; just verify no dead links	→ /guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
8	Creating Entrepreneurs in The Taxi Industry	/creating-entrepreneurs-taxi-industry/	12.0	Legal	Low — niche; add link and leave	→ /a-guide-on-how-to-start-a-taxi-business-in-south-africa/

#	Title	URL	Position	Theme	Refresh priority	Link target
9	Instagram for business (local brands)	/not-just-selfies-local-brands-using-instagram-business/	13.5	Growth	Medium — update with current SA social media landscape	→ /sme-guides/sales-strategies-for-small-businesses/
10	Five questions to ask before choosing a bank	/five-questions-ask-choosing-bank-business/	18.1	Funding	Medium — verify bank options still current	→ /sme-review/top-business-credit-cards/
11	How I successfully cracked foreign markets	/successfully-cracked-foreign-markets/	18.3	Growth	Low — founder story; just link	→ sales strategy hub
12	TEDA's Funding Fair to Focus on SME Support and Growth	/tedas-funding-fair-focus-sme-support-growth/	18.8	Funding	Check: Is TEDA still active? If programme ended → redirect to /guide-government-funding/	→ /guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
13	Entrepreneur cultivates new market	/entrepreneur-cultivates-new-market-many-fear-trade/	18.8	Legal	Low — link and leave	→ /guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
14	'I Financed My Business Out Of My Own Pocket'	/financed-business-pocket-tebogo-ditshego/	5.5	Funding	Low — founder story, good position; just link	→ /guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
15	Steve Mululu: 'The key to wealth is your health'	/steve-mululu-key-wealth-health/	1.4	Funding	Low — verify person still active/relevant	→ /5-key-success-factors-of-businesses/

#	Title	URL	Position	Theme	Refresh priority	Link target
16	The Secret Behind ImageCorp's Success	/entrepreneurship-blood-tanya-naidoo/	2.3	Profile	Low — link and leave	→ /5-key-success-factors-of-businesses/
17	10 Things About Richard Maponya	/10-things-maybe-didnt-know-richard-maponya/	3.6	Other	Low — notable SA entrepreneur; link and leave	→ /5-key-success-factors-of-businesses/
18	Education Startup finds success in an unlikely market	/education-startup-finds-success-unlikely-market-2/	10.5	Growth	Low — link and leave	→ sales strategy hub

Link Architect instruction: Run these 18 posts through Link Architect as a separate batch, distinct from the Phase 1 batch of 6. Use the "Link target" column above to configure outbound link destinations.

Category B — Light Refresh + Link (7 posts)

These 7 posts have minor ranking signals. No structural rewrite needed — date update, a quick accuracy check, and 1-2 inbound links is sufficient.

#	Title	URL	Position	Action
1	5 ways to build a 21st century business	/5-ways-build-21st-century-business/	1.0	Update date, add link from growth hub
2	Cost effective way of chasing business leads	/cost-effective-way-chasing-business-leads/	4.3	Update with modern digital lead gen context; link from sales strategy hub
3	Tax Guide for Your SME	/tax-guide-sme/	27.4	Flag: Competing with Phase 2 tax hub. Review content — if duplicate, redirect to /a-guide-on-small-business-tax/. If unique angle, update 2026 figures and link
4	Building a catering empire with inspiration from the East	/building-catering-empire-inspiration-east/	11.0	Link to /faqs-licenses-and-permits-food-service-2/ and coffee shop guide
5	5 ways a University Degree can be useful to entrepreneurs	/5-ways-university-degree-can-useful-entrepreneurs/	12.0	Link to /5-key-success-factors-of-businesses/
6	3 Ways To Become a More Skilled Risk Taker	/3-ways-become-skilled-risk-taker/	17.5	Light update; link to /5-key-success-factors-of-businesses/
7	Smartbucks innovator becomes teacher to 45 000 students	/smartbucks-innovator-becomes-teacher-45-000-students/	25.5	Verify company still active; link to growth hub or prune if defunct

Note on #3 (Tax Guide for Your SME at pos 27.4): This post may be competing with the Phase 2 tax hub consolidation. Check whether it was included in the redirect batch for /sme-guides/guide-to-business-tax-in-south-africa/. If not, redirect it now.

Category C — Keep + Link Only (12 posts)

These 12 posts rank for specific niche or branded queries and should not be touched editorially. Add 1-2 contextual inbound links per post via Link Architect and leave them alone.

#	Title	URL	Position	Link from
1	Entrepreneurs bust common startup myths	/entrepreneurs-bust-common-startup-myths/	1.0	/5-key-success-factors-of-businesses/
2	Shell refuels its SME development programme	/shell-refuels-sme-development-programme/	1.0	/guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
3	SAB Kickstart Bootcamp — De Wet Tshonto	/started-diamond-business-22/	2.0	/guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
4	'Blood, sweat and tears' - Evegenia Poplett	/blood-sweat-tears-thats-built-business-evegenia-poplett/	2.0	/5-key-success-factors-of-businesses/
5	'It takes unshakable faith' - Wendy Ferguson	/takes-unshakable-faith-abilities-sometimes-raw-guts-wendy-ferguson/	2.0	/5-key-success-factors-of-businesses/
6	Youth Chamber of Commerce	/youth-chamber-commerce-give-voice-young-entrepreneurs/	3.0	/guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
7	Corporate support for youth entrepreneurs	/corporate-support-youth-entrepreneurs-2/	4.5	/guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
8	Succession planning	/succession-planning-strategy-business-future-success/	5.6	/5-key-success-factors-of-businesses/
9	ICT startup bridges SA's internet divide	/ict-startup-bridges-south-africas-internet-divide/	6.0	/5-key-success-factors-of-businesses/
10	Bequester Startup Restarts	/bequester-startup-restarts-second-chance-success/	10.0	/guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
11	Guide to Gauteng Enterprise Propeller Programme	/guide-gauteng-enterprise-propeller-programme/	13.0	/guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
12	Startup WumDrop Personalises Courier Services	/microsoft-bizspark-programme-gives-tech-startups-boost-2/	13.2	/top-10-courier-companies-in-south-africa/

Link Architect run: Add as a third batch (separate from Phase 1 batch and Category A batch above).

Category D — Prune / Redirect: Implementation Protocol (238 posts)

Why this is the single most impactful action remaining

Google's Helpful Content system evaluates content quality at both the page level and the domain level. 238 thin 2014 posts with no rankings, no traffic, and no topical signal actively lower the domain-wide quality score. Removing them from Google's index tells Google: "this site is about high-quality SME content." That message compounds over months.

Expected timeline: Quality signal improvement typically appears 8-16 weeks after systematic pruning begins, showing as broader index coverage and gradual position improvements across pages that were not directly touched.

Implementation rules

Rule 1: Check for external backlinks before actioning any post. Run each batch through Ahrefs/SEMrush "Backlink Checker" or use GSC's Links report. Any post with 5+ quality external backlinks should receive a 301 redirect rather than a noindex, to preserve the link equity.

Rule 2: Batch size — maximum 30 posts per week. Implement on Tuesdays (Google tends to process crawl queue updates early in the week). Wait at least 5-7 days between batches.

Rule 3: Prioritise zero-ranking posts first (Weeks 1-4), ranked posts last (Weeks 5-10). Posts with no position signal are the safest to remove. Posts with positions (even at pos 70-100) may have a small residual signal — do these last after monitoring confirms no negative impact from the first batches.

Rule 4: Record every action. Keep a spreadsheet logging: post URL, action taken (noindex/redirect), redirect destination (if applicable), date processed. You'll need this to undo if needed and to track in GSC.

Redirect targets by theme

Where a 301 redirect is appropriate (posts with backlinks or closely matching hub content):

Post theme	Redirect destination
Funding/Finance	/guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
Advice/Guides (general)	/sme-guides/ category page
Advice/Legal/Compliance	/sme-guides/business-licences-in-south-africa/
Growth/Marketing	/sme-guides/sales-strategies-for-small-businesses-in-south-africa/ (once live)
Founder Profile	/ (homepage) — only if it has backlinks; otherwise noindex
Startup/Ecosystem	/guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
Business Tips	/5-key-success-factors-of-businesses/
Community/Social	/guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
Other/Unclassified	Noindex (no contextually appropriate destination)

WordPress bulk noindex method

Via Yoast + Quick Edit (small batches):

1. Posts → All Posts → filter by Category or date range to surface the 2014 posts
2. Quick Edit each post → Yoast SEO section → set to "noindex"
3. Works well for batches of 10-15

Via WP-CLI (for developer — faster for large batches): Query posts by date range and update the Yoast noindex meta field. Your developer can script this as a single database operation per batch rather than editing posts one by one. Yoast stores noindex as `_yoast_wpseo_meta-robots-noindex` in post meta.

Verification after each batch: Wait 1 week, then check GSC → Coverage → Excluded → "Excluded by 'noindex' tag" — confirm the actioned URLs appear there. If they don't appear within 2 weeks, the noindex may not be applying correctly — investigate Yoast settings.

PART C — Technical SEO Audit Checklist

Run once now, then review quarterly.

Yoast Configuration Audit

Check	What to verify	Fix if needed
Sitemap includes cornerstones	All pages marked "Cornerstone" in Yoast should appear in sitemap.xml	Yoast → SEO → General → Features → XML sitemaps enabled
Noindexed pages excluded from sitemap	Pages set to noindex should NOT appear in sitemap	Yoast handles this automatically — spot-check 5 noindexed URLs to confirm they're absent
Category pages indexed	Are the /sme-funding/, /sme-guides/ category/archive pages in the sitemap?	Yoast → Search Appearance → Taxonomies → check each is set to "Show in search results"
Custom post types (JetEngine funding applications)	Confirm the noindex applied in the original brief is still in place	Yoast → Search Appearance → Post Types → funding application CPT → set to "noindex"
Author archive pages	Unless author pages have meaningful content, these should be noindexed	Yoast → Search Appearance → Archives → Author archives
Date archive pages	Should be noindexed — Google doesn't need /2014/08/ archives	Yoast → Search Appearance → Archives → Date archives
Breadcrumb schema	Yoast breadcrumbs should be enabled site-wide for structured navigation	Yoast → Search Appearance → Breadcrumbs → Enabled
Meta descriptions filled	Run Yoast bulk edit report — flag any pages with missing meta descriptions	Yoast → SEO → Tools → Bulk editor → Meta descriptions
Duplicate title tags	Flag any posts with identical title tags	Yoast → SEO → Tools → Bulk editor → Titles

Link Whisper Configuration Review

Check	What to verify
No links to Category D orphans	After the orphan prune operation, scan Link Whisper's existing suggested/applied links for any pointing to soon-to-be noindexed URLs. Remove those links.

Check	What to verify
Hub pages are "link targets"	Confirm the 6 Phase 1-2 hub pages (/the-basics-of-how-to-register/, /guide-government-funding/, /seda-grant-funding/, /sme-resources/business-plan-template/, /sme-guides/a-guide-to-b-bbee/, /a-guide-on-small-business-tax/) are all appearing as frequent suggestions
No reciprocal link loops	Check that Tshepho's Ops Link Architect hasn't created mutual links between two pages that both link back to each other with identical anchors — this can look unnatural
Anchor text diversity	Spot-check 10 hub pages — no anchor text should appear more than 3-4 times in the same form across all inbound links

Subdomain Strategy — advice.smesouthafrica.co.za

The BuddyBoss forum at `advice.smesouthafrica.co.za` is a separate subdomain. Google treats subdomains as separate entities from the root domain for most ranking purposes. This means:

- **Forum threads ranking well (pos 5-15)** are not directly contributing to the main domain's authority. Their links to the main domain help, but the subdomain's own ranking signals stay on the subdomain.
- **Current forum threads with significant impressions** should each have a pinned moderator note linking to the equivalent main-domain article.

Forum threads needing pinned notes (all covered in Phases 1-3):

Forum thread	Pinned note links to
How_do_I_register_my_business_in_South_Africa	/the-basics-of-how-to-register-a-small-business-in-south-africa/
effective_sales_strategies_and_tactic	/sme-guides/sales-strategies-for-small-businesses-in-south-africa/
What_are_sources_of_capital_for_a_startup	/guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
Getting_Funding	/guide-government-funding-small-businesses/
How_to_Obtain_a_Business_License_Application_Form	/sme-guides/business-licences-in-south-africa/
When_and_how_often_should_I_declare_my_income	/a-guide-on-small-business-tax/
How_can_I_successfully_start_selling_my_products_on_Takealot	/how-to-become-a-seller-on-takealot/
Gas_refill_station_requirements	/how-to-start-a-gas-refill-business-in-south-africa/
Cleaning_company_start_up	/how-to-start-a-cleaning-services-business/
What_legal_structure_should_I_choose_for_my_business	/the-basics-of-how-to-register-a-small-business-in-south-africa/

PART D — Monthly GSC Monitoring Framework

The Recovery Dashboard — Track Monthly

Pull from Google Search Console every first Monday of the month. Compare to the prior month and the August 2025 peak.

Tier 1 — Site-Level Health

KPI	Where to find	Current baseline (May 2026)	Recovery target (Month 6)
Total monthly clicks	GSC → Performance → Date range: last 28 days	~9,000	25,000+

KPI	Where to find	Current baseline (May 2026)	Recovery target (Month 6)
Total monthly impressions	Same	~1.5M	3.5M+
Average CTR	Same	~1.1%	1.8%+
Average position	Same	~14-18	10-14
Indexed pages	GSC → Coverage → Valid	Check current	Stable or growing after prune
Pages excluded (noindex)	GSC → Coverage → Excluded → noindex	Track increase as Category D posts are processed	Should reach ~280+ once all D posts actioned

Tier 2 — Hub Page Tracker

Track each Phase 1/2/3 refreshed page individually. Check monthly.

Page	Baseline position	Baseline clicks/month	90-day target position	90-day click target
/the-basics-of-how-to-register-a-small-business/	18.09	~1,200	5-10	5,000-10,000
/guide-government-funding-small-businesses/	19.68	~1,585	5-10	10,000-18,000
/sme-funding/ (category)	22.33	~3,883	10-15	8,000-15,000
/10-cheapest-franchises-in-south-africa/	16.56	~15,738	6-10	20,000-25,000
/non-profit-organisation-npo-funding/	19.07	~6,776	5-8	18,000-24,000
/a-guide-on-small-business-tax/	21.98	~780	8-15	3,000-6,000
/sme-guides/a-guide-to-b-bbee-for-businesses-in-south-africa/	28.83	~314	8-18	2,500-5,000
/sme-resources/business-plan-template-for-small-businesses/	26.75	~541	6-12	4,000-7,000
/sme-review/top-business-loans-for-small-businesses-in-south-africa/	37.73	~180	10-20	3,000-6,000

Tier 3 — Off-Brand Cleanup Tracker

Confirm off-brand impressions are declining monthly. These should trend toward zero as noindex tags are processed by Google.

Page	Baseline impressions	Month 1	Month 2	Month 3	Target
/paxi-from-pep-logistics-to-partner-with-for-parcel-delivery/ (rewrite)	910,649	—	—	—	Impressions should shift to SME delivery intent queries
/brands/sage/	256,254	—	—	—	0 (noindexed)
/brands/afrihost-web-hosting-review/	201,367	—	—	—	0 (noindexed)
/brands/nedbank-small-business-credit-card/	177,858	—	—	—	0 (noindexed)
/how-to-become-a-seller-on-takealot/ (rewrite)	404,449	—	—	—	CTR should move from 0.5% toward 2%+

Tier 4 — Anomaly Alerts

Review these signals monthly — if triggered, investigate before taking further action:

- **Sudden drop >20% in total impressions week-on-week** → Possible new algorithm update. Check Google Search Status Dashboard. Do not panic-redirect content.
- **Any Phase 1/2 refreshed page drops >5 positions after refresh** → Check if the refresh accidentally removed important content or introduced a thin section. Revert or add depth.
- **Indexed page count drops unexpectedly** → Confirm the Coverage report's "Valid" count is dropping only due to intentional Category D noindexing, not from legitimate pages being removed.
- **CTR drops on any hub page despite stable position** → Indicates a competitor has introduced a rich snippet (FAQ, HowTo) that pushes your result down visually. Add or improve FAQ/HowTo schema on that page.
- **Forum subdomain impressions increase sharply** → New forum thread is ranking for a high-volume query. Add pinned link to main domain article immediately.

Phase 3 Master Checklist

Developer (one-time):

- ☐ Business loans: 3 redirects implemented
- ☐ Banking cards: 1 redirect (best-business-banking-cards → credit cards page)
- ☐ Accounting software: check for "-2" duplicate; redirect if found
- ☐ All Phase 1-2 forum pinned notes confirmed live (see table above)

- ☐ New forum thread pins added for Phase 3 (sales, licences, income declaration, Takealot, gas)
- ☐ Yoast configuration audit completed (see checklist above)
- ☐ Link Whisper audit: no links to Category D orphan URLs
- ☐ Author archive pages: noindexed in Yoast

Editor (scheduled over 8-10 weeks):

- ☐ Business loans article: refreshed and live
- ☐ Sales strategy hub: new article published at correct URL
- ☐ Labour law guide: refreshed with 2026 NMW rates
- ☐ Business licences hub: refreshed + linked to spoke pages
- ☐ Batch refresh: coffee shop, cleaning, Airbnb, real estate, logistics (one per week)
- ☐ Category A orphans: refreshed and submitted for Link Architect batch
- ☐ Category B orphans: light refresh + date update complete
- ☐ /sme-review/ category: refresh calendar set up for November 2026 annual pass

Developer (orphan operation — 8-10 weeks rolling):

- ☐ Week 1: Batch 1 — 25-30 zero-ranking posts from Category D noindexed
- ☐ Week 2: Batch 2 — 25-30 zero-ranking posts noindexed
- ☐ Week 3-6: Continue batches, confirm GSC Coverage exclusions growing
- ☐ Week 7-9: Process Category D posts with low rankings (pos 40-100)
- ☐ Week 10: Final batch; full review of Coverage report
- ☐ Backlink check complete for any Category D post flagged for external links
- ☐ Record sheet maintained throughout (URL, action, date, redirect destination)

Ongoing (monthly):

- ☐ GSC monitoring dashboard pulled and reviewed
- ☐ Tier 1-4 checks completed
- ☐ Any anomalies documented and actioned